

idea of "breath," the Avestan starts from the verb "think." A smaller point I may just name before I pass from this comparison. In *Ys* 33^b we read of "the Dominion of Good Thought" (*χῥαθράμ νανθῶν mananhō*). So we may have one of the Hexad depending on another, instead of on Mazdah. It is perhaps not too fanciful to compare the occasional appearance of τὸ πνεῦμα Ἰησοῦ or Χριστοῦ in the New Testament as a designation of the Third Person of the Trinity.

I must pass on from these necessarily abtruse points of theology, in which it is easy for one who is neither philosopher nor expert in the history of dogma to stumble. Whether my comparison hitherto has been just or fanciful, I am on sure ground when I point out the general resemblance of the paths by which the two religions reached the heights of monotheism. To each people when polytheism still reigned there came a great Prophet, the centre of whose message was to bid them fix their thought and faith on One alone. But neither Moses nor Zarathushtra denied the existence of other beings called divine. The Gathas know nothing of gods who could be regarded as inferior to Mazdah but on his side. For Zarathushtra, we should judge, the step was already taken which late in Israel's history made the gods of other peoples real divinities, but of devilish nature. In the Inscriptions, however, Ahura Mazdah is "the greatest of gods (*maθiṣṭa bagānām*)," and these "gods (*baga*)" are beneficent. We may assume safely that if Zarathushtra tried to ignore these inferior deities he failed to carry his people with him. The growth of monotheism, after the primary impulse was spent, lay along the same lines in both nations.

The transcendence of the one national deity—Ahura Mazdah, “the God of the Aryans,” Yahweh, “the God of Israel”—became more and more marked with time; and ultimately the nation reached a real monotheism by this road. In each case there is a possibility that the Founder reached it ages before. It may be added that the lines of religious declension were much the same. The old polytheism in each case constantly threatened to return. Mithra and Anahita might in theory be only *yazata*, angels subordinated to the only God, just as in medieval Christianity Michael and the Virgin were by theologians kept wholly apart from Deity. But with the populace the distinction was unreal, and polytheism virtually returned, as it did throughout the history of Israel before the Captivity.

The part played by the Prophet may be compared with suggestive results. Zarathushtra stands solitary in the history of Parsism, while Moses has a series of successors, some of whom were at least as great as himself. There lies the most important part of the ultimate difference between the destiny of the religions. In other respects the parallel will hold. Each Founder was credited in later days with a complete legislative system, which in Zarathushtra's case was the work of men wholly alien¹ from his spirit. By way of compensation, the men who mis-

¹ Here I must chronicle the fact that my friend Prof. Jackson sprinkles queries about these two words. His opinion is worth so much more than mine that the reader should be told when I am venturing without his company. My main contention is that the *ritual* of the Vendidad was alien to Zarathushtra, who, as I understand him, had nothing of the ritual or the sacerdotal in his system. But I have no doubt that without their adaptation Zarathushtra's thought would have failed to survive.

cannot determine; nor can we say with certainty how early the idea appeared in Israel. It is said by Dr Skinner to appear first unambiguously in 2 Macc. 7²⁸, dated not long before our era. Even this passage is questioned by Hatch (*Hibbert Lectures*, p. 195 f.), who would make the Gnostic Basilides the earliest to announce the doctrine.¹

Two other striking features may be noticed in which the concept of Deity approximates in the two religions. That "God is light, and in Him is no darkness at all" is a doctrine too familiar to need further illustration. But Parsism from the first lays quite equal stress on the idea. In the anthropomorphic phrase, Ahura "clothes himself with the massy heavens," even as Yahweh "cover[s him]self with light as with a garment." Later we have the splendid phrase that the body of Ahura is like the light and his soul like Truth.² This is as immaterial a conception as could be easily devised, and it fits in with the constant insistence on the spiritual nature of God. Prof. Söderblom well brings out the fundamental antithesis of *corporeal* and *spiritual* (*astvant* and *mainyava*). It goes back to early times, and may be called an alternative dualism. He notes that the Jewish fundamental antithesis was rather between the present age and the future.³ Ahura is wholly spiritual, and surrounded by spirits. The great Johannine saying that God is Spirit, and His

¹ I owe the reference to my colleague Prof. A. S. Peake.

² See p. 391 for its original Greek (Porphyry).

³ *Les Fravashis*, 60 f. The division cuts across the other dualistic division: cf. the illustrations quoted from Prof. Söderblom above, p. 147 f.